

Recognise that character!

OCR software come in handy when you just need to have an image file of that magazine. Here's how we recognised and characterised the software that does character reading in the true sense of the word...

Though OCR (Optical Character Recognition) software still has a long way to go, there are a couple out there that make it easy for you to feed any kind of document into your scanner, and expect a faithful reproduction without nagging formatting errors. Some software do a decent job of OCRing when there are no smudges, formatting idiosyncrasies and such, but falter when these are present. The new breed of OCR software is being infused with AI. This holds promise, but AI technology in OCR seems to be still in its infancy.

So why do you need OCR software—just use your imagination. You could scan newspaper articles and save them as a searchable library, instead of maintaining a bulk of yellowing newsprint. All those business faxes could go into a neat folder. What about those ancient dot-matrix printouts you can't afford to throw away? OCR and de-paper them.

With most OCR software available today, OCRing essentially requires you to first scan your document, and then press the 'recognise' button. What happens after that varies considerably from software to software. As our test results show, there are good as well as poor OCR programs out there. Use our results to decide what's best for your OCRing needs.

Cuneiform Pro 6.0 An Average Performer

Cuneiform does an ordinary job of scanning ordinary documents, i.e., standard inkjet or laser printouts. However, don't expect it to handle newspaper clips or Microsoft Excel

sheets in short, anything that might confuse it with graphs, images, columns, multiple fonts and so on. Cuneiform is light—both in terms of performance and price.

The vertical white lines that appear in a fax flummoxed the software, and recognition was poor. Ditto for photocopies. Cuneiform also cannot read 'reverse font', i.e., white print on a black background. It doesn't seem to have any in-built intelligence engine: if your document is scanned sideways, you need to manually rotate it in Cuneiform before it will recognise it. The worst of Cuneiform we saw was for the newspaper clip: it recognised virtually nothing, and all we got was one line of text, without any column retention.

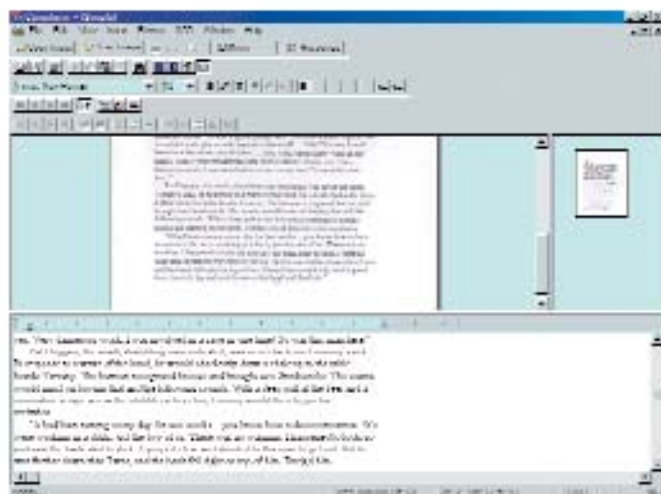
Coming to the positive points, it has a batch-recognition mode for, say, scanning a textbook. Simply save all your scanned images in one directory, and instruct

Cuneiform to recognise the images one by one. The menus and buttons are simple and intuitive—for example, it has buttons for 'Scan Image' and 'Load Image', instead of the slightly ambiguous 'acquire' in other software.

You can help Cuneiform help you—there is a good manual

layout feature available that lets you define areas of text, images and so on, in the image, thus ensuring that the software does not get confused or thrown off at the interfaces.

The documented help is pretty good, and online help is available at the click of a button. The text editor that is used after OCRing is comprehensive, and has all the standard formatting buttons. The spell-checker is satisfactory, and Cuneiform highlights suspect words while showing you the point in the original document where they occur. You can opt to retain or ignore fonts, italics and so on. It also has a bundled editor of its own, which is akin to a word processor that you can use independent of OCRing. The quick-recognise feature helps you bypass starting up the software—simply run quick-recognise by going to Start > Programs > Cuneiform > Quick-recognise, and give



Cuneiform can't recognise the orientation of the image